

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ K 7 5 3

♥ J 9

♦ J 8 5 2

♣ Q 10 4

♠ J 10 9 4

♥ K Q 2

♦ A K 9

♣ K 7 6



♠ 6

♥ A 10 8 6 4

♦ 10 7 3

♣ J 8 3 2

♠ A Q 8 2

♥ 7 5 3

♦ Q 6 4

♣ A 9 5

West

North

East

South

1NT

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by North

Lead: ♥6

You have lost two tricks so far. Lead the ♠J and let it ride. West wins their third trick with the ♠K but has no ♥ to return so he plays a ♦ which you win with your ♦A.

Play off your 7 winners and give up a ♣ at the end.

The K Q x holding is similar to the A J x holding. It might be two stoppers, or might just be one, depending on which defender next leads the suit.

So you decide whether to hold up or not based on how you expect to play the hand.

With his 4-3-3-3 distribution South chooses not to bother with Stayman. North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♥6. West plays the ♥J.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=1 ♦=3 ♣=2 Total = 7

You need to get two more winners. The ♥ suit might provide one of them, but you will still have to establish ♠s. The burning question is whether to win the first ♥ or to hold up. If you take this trick you will have a second stopper if East takes the lead, but you will be in extreme danger if West takes the lead. Since the ♠ finesse has to go into West you should hold up.

West returns the ♥9, East takes the ♥A and clears the suit.

Board 2

South Deals

None Vul

♠ K 3
♥ A 10 8 6 4
♦ 10 7 3
♣ J 8 3

♠ J 10 9 4

♥ 7 5 3

♦ A K 9

♣ A 9 5



♠ 7 6 5

♥ J 9

♦ J 8 5 2

♣ Q 10 4 2

♠ A Q 8 2

♥ K Q 2

♦ Q 6 4

♣ K 7 6

West	North	East	South
			1NT

Pass 3NT

All Pass

3NT by South

Lead: ♥6

West cannot play ♥s without setting up your ♥Q so he will probably exit with a ♣ which you take with the ♣K.

Play off your 6 winners and concede the last three tricks.

This was almost the same as Deal 5, the difference being in which direction the ♠ finesse had to be taken.

But it sure makes a big difference in how you play the hand.

This might have turned out even better. If West had decided to play his partner for the ♥Q, (who would have played ♥J from a holding of ♥ Q J x), you would have made an overtrick!

With his 4-3-3-3 distribution North chooses not to bother with Stayman. South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♥6. East plays the ♥J.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=1 ♦=3 ♣=2 Total = 7

You need to get two more winners. The ♥ suit might provide one of them, but you will still have to establish ♠s. The burning question is whether to win the first ♥ or to hold up. If you take this trick you will have a second stopper if West takes the lead, but you will be in extreme danger if East takes the lead. Since the ♠ finesse has to go into West you should not hold up.

You win with your ♥K, (keeping West in the dark about who holds the ♥Q), enter dummy with the ♦A and play the ♠J, letting it ride to West's ♠K.

Board 3

West Deals

E-W Vul

♠ J 6

♥ K Q J 10 8 7 6

♦ 10 6 2

♣ 4

♠ A 9 2

♥ A 9 2

♦ K Q 4

♣ A Q 7 6

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W		E
	S	

♠ K Q 10 8 3

♥ 4

♦ J 8 7 3

♣ K 5 2

♠ 7 5 4

♥ 5 3

♦ A 9 5

♣ J 10 9 8 3

West

3♥

North

3NT

East

South

All Pass

3NT by North

Lead: ♥4

doubleton he would have led a higher card. So there is no need to hold up. But . . . it couldn't hurt, could it?

Yes, it could hurt real bad! Suppose West has nothing in his hand but the ♥ K Q J 10 8 7 6 that you already know about. When you let his ♥10 win the first trick he will realize that his hand is dead. And he may be smart enough, (or lucky enough), to switch to a ♠.

The purpose of the hold-up play is to cut communications between the two defenders. So the general guideline is to hold up until you are sure one of the defenders is void in the suit - maybe twice, maybe only once, and in this case not at all.

But one of the important considerations you have to think about is the possibility that the Defense will switch to another suit - where you might be in even more trouble.

You'd feel bad on this hand if you let West hold the ♥10 only to see him next lay down the ♠J.

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♥4. West plays the ♥10.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=1 ♦=3 ♣=1 Total = 6

You may not agree with North's 3NT bid but how else are you going to get to the only game that has a chance of making?

You need 3 extra winners and they will come from the ♣ suit even if East holds the ♣K and wins your finesse. You may think about holding up on the ♥A for one round just to make sure East has none if he wins the ♣K.

That would be a mistake. It is almost certain that West has a 7-card ♥ suit for his preemptive opening.

This is confirmed by East's lead of the ♥4, with a

Board 4
East Deals
None Vul

♠ 9 3
♥ J 9 5 4
♦ 8 7 3
♣ Q 7 4 2

♠ Q 10 6 2
♥ K 7 6
♦ A Q J 9
♣ 9 5



♠ 4
♥ A Q 10 2
♦ K 6 4
♣ K 10 8 6 3

♠ A K J 8 7 5
♥ 8 3
♦ 10 5 2
♣ A J

West	North	East	South
		1♣	1♠
Pass	2♣	Pass	4♠
All Pass			
4♠ by South			
Lead: ♣2			
can get the lead with is the ♣Q.			

North's 2♣ cue-bid shows a limit-raise or better in ♠s. South is to play 4♠. West leads the ♣2. East plays the ♣K.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 4

You have one loser too many. If West holds either the ♥A or the ♦K this will be an easy contract, but East opened the bidding so he probably has most of the high cards. It does look like West holds the ♣Q based on his low lead and East's play to trick one.

Having gone through that thought process what is your Plan?

You will need to discard a loser on dummy's fourth ♦, but you must do so without ever letting West gain the lead since West is the defender who can lead through dummy's ♥K. And the only card that West

Hold-ups are usually used in notrump hands, but here you use one to prevent the Danger Hand from gaining the lead. Let East have the ♣K. He cannot play a red card without helping you so he will surely play another ♣.

Pull trumps in two rounds. Then play the ♦10 and let it ride.

East will win this but he is helpless. Whatever he plays you will be able to discard a ♥ loser on dummy's ♦.

The purpose of the hold-up play is to cut communications between the two defenders. Here you knew you would lose exactly one ♣ trick so you chose to lose it to East, the Safe Hand.

If you had taken the first ♣ trick East would have won your later ♦ finesse, put his partner on lead with the ♣Q and then swallowed up your ♥K.

Of course if West had been clever enough to lead a ♥ originally this Deal wouldn't be here.